taking new pictures of Soviet missile sites. The Soviet officers knew exactly what was going on: the positions they had built with such effort were being exposed. At the command post of the 27th Antiaircraft Division in Camagüey Major Serovoi was besieged with demands from regimental commanders to allow them to shoot down the intruder. Eager to see action at last, they had their Desna S-75 surface-to-air missiles, like the one that had shot down Gary Powers in 196o, ready to fire.

"The commanders of anti-aircraft missile regiments began asking me insistently to allow them to open fire, maintaining that this was indeed a direct attack," recalled Serovoi. "Others considered that the scout could not be allowed to get away scot-free with his reconnaissance data about our positions: after him, there would be a crushing bomb strike against the positions. I repeat that at that moment we were intent on repelling an attack; we had not yet 'cooled down.' "[13]

Major Serovoi called Pliev's headquarters, located in an underground bunker at the El Chico estate near Havana, where the duty officer was General Stepan Grechko, the fifty-two-year-old chief of staff of the Moscow air defense region, who had been dispatched to Cuba to serve as Pliev's deputy in charge of air defense. He had two divisions armed with Desna S-75 surface-to-air missiles under his command. They had been brought to Cuba ahead of Statsenko's missile regiments to protect them from discovery by American U-2 spy planes. But now the Americans were flying unobstructed over Statsenko's installations, making Grechko's whole mission pointless. With a strike or invasion around the corner, the nuclear missile sites Grechko was supposed to protect were turning into sitting ducks for American bombers.

Serovoi told Grechko that "the unit commanders are insisting that the reconnaissance plane be destroyed." Grechko did not know what to do, and Pliev was not around. After a sleepless night the sickly commander, struggling with kidney disease, had gone to get some rest. General Garbuz, who reached the command post around 10:00 a.m. that morning, remembered Grechko telling him that he could not reach Pliev because he was sick. Serovoi recalled that the debate between Grechko's headquarters and the regimental commanders on whether to shoot down the American plane went on for at least half an hour. "General Grechko advised not to